

The revelations about her visions brought Hildegard considerable fame and numerous converts, inspiring her to found her own convent at Rupertsberg near Bingen (from where her name is derived) around 1148. She also later founded a second monastery, at Eibingen, on the hillside above Rüdesheim on the east bank of the Rhine, but never lived there. At the age of 60, Hildegard began a series of preaching tours in Germany that focused on her visions and spiritual insights—a bold and courageous decision for a woman of that period in a ferociously patriarchal world. Among Hildegard’s passions and numerous talents was music: paradise, for her, was to be filled with it. She maintained that her compositions “completed” her visions. Her pieces always combine music and words—she perceived the two to be inextricably connected: “The words symbolize the body, and the ... music indicates the spirit.”

Music was fundamental to life in the cloisters and Hildegard would have been familiar with chant genres, including Gregorian chant (the plainsong or liturgical chant of medieval church music), and may have been exposed to some secular music (see box, opposite). She would also probably have been aware of the work of the 11th-century German composers and theorists Hermanus Contractus and Berno of Reichenau.

However, as Hildegard indicates in her writings, she was largely uneducated and had never studied music, form, or composition. Her work, by all accounts, was propelled by her visionary experiences. The literary scholar and linguist Mark Atherton has suggested that Hildegard’s technique departs substantially from the accepted conventions of Gregorian plainsong: “Her melody